

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 45

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A young clarinettist auditions for a place at a music school, and discovers that a single accident in the middle of her programme may not, in the end, decide everything.

1

The audition room had been emptied of everything that was not strictly necessary. A grand piano, lid closed, stood in one corner like a tactful witness. Three chairs faced a single music stand. Behind the chairs, three panellists sat with the still, neutral expressions of people who had heard a great many promising young musicians that morning and were determined not to encourage any of them too early. I bowed, set my clarinet to my lips, and waited for the small nod that meant **begin**.

2

For the first piece, a Mozart andante, the room behaved itself. My fingers found the keys without being asked. The phrases I had practised at home, hour after hour, came out into the air almost exactly as I had imagined them — perhaps a little brighter than I had dared to hope. When the last note faded, the woman in the middle made a small mark on her page and asked, without looking up, for my second piece. I lifted the instrument again, drew in a careful breath, and began the Weber.

3

It happened in the eighth bar. A tiny, papery crack — felt rather than heard — and the note I was holding splintered into a thin, ugly buzz. My reed had split. I knew at once what had happened; every clarinettist does. For a fraction of a second I considered carrying on, hoping the panellists would not notice. They had already noticed. The man on the left had stopped writing. The woman in the middle had looked up. The third panellist, a tall man with kind eyes, was watching me with the slightly weary patience of someone waiting to see what I would do next.

4

I lowered the clarinet. The silence in the room was complete and enormous. Somewhere far away, in a corridor, a door closed. I could hear my own pulse. I think the easiest thing in that moment would have

been to apologise, to fumble out an excuse, to ask whether I might begin again, and to leave the audition with the small, dignified injury of an interrupted performance. Instead, I heard myself say, quite calmly, “May I change my reed?” The woman in the middle nodded once. The kind-eyed man almost smiled.

5

I knelt by my open case. My hands, I noticed with surprise, were not shaking. I removed the split reed, set it aside, took a fresh one from its small plastic sleeve, and moistened it as I had moistened a thousand reeds before, in a thousand quieter rooms. I tightened the ligature. I tested the new reed with a single, low, exploratory note that bloomed unexpectedly into the empty space, soft and full. The kind-eyed man nodded, as though to himself. I stood up. I lifted the instrument. I began the Weber again, from the top.

6

The second attempt was, in truth, better than the first would have been. Something in the interruption had settled me. The notes I had been gripping too tightly came out loose and easy. The fast passage in the middle, the one I had been dreading for three months, slipped past me almost without my noticing. By the final cadenza I was no longer trying to impress anyone; I was simply playing, the way one plays at home for the cat. The last bar floated up, hung for a second, and dissolved. Then there was nothing in the room but the silence and the three panellists and me.

7

I do not remember what they said when they thanked me. I remember the woman in the middle made another small mark, and that the kind-eyed man, as I packed my clarinet away, murmured, “Well played.” I walked out into the corridor on legs that did not quite belong to me. A boy with a bassoon case was waiting his turn. He looked up and asked me, quietly, how it had gone. I started to say **I broke a reed**. What came out instead was, “I think it went all right.”

8

I learned later, in the letter that arrived three weeks afterwards, that I had been offered a place. For a long time I assumed the panel had been kind, or that they had decided to overlook the split reed. It was only years later, listening to a friend describe her own teaching of auditions, that I understood. The split reed had not been a disaster they forgave. It had been, in its way, the thing they were waiting to see — not whether I could play a clean Weber, but what I would do in the moment the music broke.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator describes the closed grand piano as standing “like a tactful witness.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about the atmosphere of the audition room. [2]

2. What does the narrator’s description of the three panellists suggest about how they wished to be perceived by the candidates? [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator says that for the first piece “the room behaved itself.” Explain what is **unusual** about this description, and what it suggests about the narrator’s first piece. [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. The narrator describes the sound of the split reed as a “thin, ugly buzz.” Give **two** details from Paragraph 3 that show the panellists were already aware that something had gone wrong. [2]

From Paragraph 4

5. The narrator considers apologising and asking to begin again.

- (a) Why does she describe this option as “the small, dignified injury of an interrupted performance”? [1]
(b) What does the fact that she rejects this option suggest about her at this moment? [1]

From Paragraph 5

6. The narrator notices that her hands “were not shaking.” Explain how the language used in Paragraph 5 conveys her composure as she changes the reed. Support your answer with **two** details from the paragraph. [3]

From Paragraph 6

7. The narrator says she was playing “the way one plays at home for the cat.” Explain what this comparison suggests about the way she was performing during the second attempt. [2]

8. The final note of the Weber is described as having “floated up, hung for a second, and dissolved.” What does this description suggest about the narrator’s feelings at the end of the piece? [1]

From Paragraph 7

9. Give **one** piece of evidence from Paragraph 7 that the narrator was still emotionally affected when she left the audition room. [1]

From Paragraph 8

10. The narrator writes that the panel had been waiting to see “what I would do in the moment the music broke.” Explain, in your own words, what this tells us about what the panel really valued in a candidate. [2]

11. What is the **tone** of the final paragraph of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on the vanishing art of repair and the growing right-to-repair movement.

1

A century ago, a household appliance was expected to outlive the household. The toaster, the radio, the sewing machine — each came with a small, sober booklet of diagrams and a list of spare parts that could be ordered by post. When something failed, a neighbour or a local repairer fixed it; when no one local could fix it, the manufacturer did. The notion that a five-year-old washing machine might be cheaper to replace than to repair would have struck the average buyer not merely as wasteful, but as faintly absurd. That assumption, in the space of a single generation, has quietly been reversed.

2

The reasons are partly the result of deliberate design. Many modern devices are assembled in ways that make repair difficult, sometimes impossible. Screws have been replaced by glue. Standard components have been replaced by proprietary parts. Batteries, once a user-replaceable item, are now sealed inside cases that cannot be opened without damaging the device. Service manuals, freely circulated a generation ago, are now treated by manufacturers as commercial secrets. The cumulative effect is a class of goods that look, on the shelf, almost identical to their grandparents — but that are, in practice, sealed boxes that the owner is invited to admire rather than understand.

3

The environmental case for changing this is now difficult to ignore. The United Nations estimates that the world generated roughly **62 million tonnes** of electronic waste in 2022, a figure that has nearly doubled in twelve years and is expected to keep rising. Less than a quarter of this waste is formally recycled; the rest is burned, buried, or shipped to countries with weaker regulations, where it leaches lead, mercury and other heavy metals into soil and groundwater. Every washing machine that could have been repaired but was instead replaced represents not only its own emissions but also the energy spent in manufacturing its successor.

4

A modest but striking response has emerged in living rooms and community halls. The first **repair cafe** opened in Amsterdam in 2009; today there are more than three thousand worldwide, in countries as varied as Belgium, Japan and South Africa. The format is simple. Volunteers with tools and patience meet, once a month, in a borrowed room. Strangers arrive with broken kettles, jammed bicycles, frayed lamps and silent radios. Together, repairer and owner take the object apart, identify the fault, and — about two-thirds of the time, according to the international **Repair Monitor** — succeed in restoring it. The economic value is modest; the cultural value is considerable.

5

Where citizens have led, governments are now beginning to follow. The European Union's **Right to Repair Directive**, adopted in 2024, will require manufacturers of common household appliances to make spare parts available for between seven and ten years after a product is sold, to publish repair manuals in plain language, and to design new products in such a way that ordinary tools can open them. In the United States, the picture is patchier — federal action remains slow — but several states, including New York and Minnesota, have passed their own right-to-repair laws covering consumer electronics. The pressure is no longer fringe; it has reached the agendas of regulators who, a decade ago, would have considered the matter trivial.

6

Manufacturers have not, on the whole, welcomed the change. Industry bodies argue that mandatory repairability will raise prices, slow innovation, and create safety risks where untrained users open

devices containing high-voltage components. They warn, too, that publishing service manuals will hand competitive advantage to copycats overseas. The objections deserve a hearing, but they should not be overstated. The same arguments were made against seatbelts, against catalytic converters, and against energy-efficiency labels — each of which, in due course, has become an unremarkable part of doing business.

7

What, then, will repair cost the ordinary consumer? In the short term, perhaps a little more at the till: a slightly higher sticker price for a product designed to be opened. In the medium term, however, the calculation looks rather different. A device that lasts twice as long is, by any sensible measure, half as expensive. A drawer of unused chargers becomes a smaller drawer. A landfill becomes a smaller landfill. The vanishing art of repair, it turns out, was never really about screwdrivers and solder. It was about a quieter idea — that the things we own are worth, at least occasionally, the trouble of keeping.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says that the idea of replacing a washing machine instead of repairing it would once have seemed “faintly absurd.” Explain, in your own words, what this suggests about how attitudes to ownership have changed. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** design choices that have made modern devices harder to repair. [2]

14. The writer says modern goods are “sealed boxes that the owner is invited to admire rather than understand.” Explain the writer’s **criticism** of manufacturers in this sentence. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. Why does the writer mention that “less than a quarter” of electronic waste is formally recycled? [2]

16. What is the effect of the phrase “burned, buried, or shipped to countries with weaker regulations”? [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer describes the response of repair cafes as “modest but striking.” Explain, in your own words, why this phrase is appropriate. [2]

18. The writer says that the economic value of repair cafes is “modest” but the **cultural** value is “considerable.” What does the writer mean by **cultural value** in this context? [2]

From Paragraph 5

19. Give **two** specific requirements that the European Union’s **Right to Repair Directive** will place on manufacturers. [2]

From Paragraph 6

20. The writer compares the manufacturers’ objections to past arguments against “seatbelts... catalytic converters... and energy-efficiency labels.” What is the writer’s **tone** in this comparison? [1]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer ends the article by saying that the art of repair “was about a quieter idea — that the things we own are worth, at least occasionally, the trouble of keeping.” Explain what is **effective** about ending the article in this way. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **why modern goods have become harder to repair**, and **how citizens and governments are now responding to this problem**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 5** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Modern goods have become harder to repair because ...

— END OF PAPER —